

Blood Metaphors and Metonymies in Saudi Arabic: A Cognitive Linguistics Perspective

الاستعارات والكنائيات المتعلقة بالدم في اللهجة العربية السعودية من منظور اللسانيات المعرفية

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Abstract

Blood is an essential fluid in the human body but is not regarded as a body part like the heart, hand, or eye. Consequently, it is not thoroughly studied as an embodying factor. As a source domain (SD), blood plays a vital role in conceptualizing emotions, character traits, and cultural values in many languages and cultures. This article explores the conceptualization of emotions, evaluation of others, and cultural practices in Saudi Arabic (SA). It shows that the SD of blood has extensive application in SA, generating conceptual cultural metonymies. This makes SA somewhat unique among Arabic dialects and perhaps other world languages in using blood to conceptualize emotions (anger, fear, love, sadness, shame), evaluation of others, and cultural values. The study uses qualitative methods within a cognitive linguistics framework.

Key words: blood, cultural practices, emotions, evaluation, metaphor, metonymy.

الملخص

الدم هو أحد السوائل الأساسية في جسم الإنسان، لكنه لا يُعد جزءاً من أجزاء الجسم، كالقلب، واليد، والعين. لذلك، فإنه غير مدروس دراسة كافية من حيث كونه عاملاً مجسّداً. وباعتباره حقلاً مرجعياً (SD)، فإن للدم في العديد من اللغات والثقافات دوراً حيوياً في تشكيل المفاهيم المتعلقة بالمشاعر، والسمات الشخصية، والقيم الثقافية. من هذا الجانب، ترمي هذه الدراسة إلى اكتشاف تشكيل المفاهيم الخاصة بالمشاعر، وتقييم الآخرين، والممارسات الثقافية في اللهجة السعودية (SA). وتُظهر الدراسة أن الحقل المرجعي للدم واسع الاستخدام في اللهجة السعودية لتوليد الاستعارات الثقافية المفاهيمية، مما يجعلها فريدة نوعاً ما بين لهجات اللغة العربية الأخرى، وربما بين لغات العالم في استخدام الدم كمفهوم لتشكيل المشاعر (الغضب، الخوف، الحب، الحزن، العيب، إلخ) وتقييم الآخرين، والتعبير عن القيم الثقافية. وتعتمد الدراسة المنهجية النوعية ضمن إطار اللغويات المعرفية.

كلمات مفتاحية: الدم، ممارسات ثقافية، مشاعر، تقييم، استعارة، كناية.



1. Introduction

Physiologically, the human body is imbued with and/or emits various fluids such as blood, sweat, saliva, tears, and urine. Notably, only blood permanently resides inside the body, and its leaving or overflowing the body is seen as unnatural and hazardous for human life, while keeping the other fluids inside the body might be fatal. This is physiology. In terms of the blood-culture link, the manipulation of blood occupies a preponderant place in many languages and cultures in the guise of "cultural conceptualizations" (Sharifian, 2003) of various emotions, cultural values, and personal attributes. In particular, as a source domain (SD), blood is exploited in conceptualizing many daily experiences owing to its value in sustaining human life.

Although "blood" is not treated as a body part in the literature on embodiment, all body parts are imbued with it. The use of the lexical item "blood" in metaphors and metonymies is under-researched as compared to the now massive literature on body parts in the guise of embodiment through two seminal book collections (Ziemke et al, 2007; Frank et al, 2008), and internal and external body parts through another two book collections (Sharifian et al, 2008; Maalej & Yu, 2011). For one, Maalej devoted three separate studies to the heart (2008), the eye (2011), and head and hand (2014) in Tunisian Arabic (TA).

This study brings evidence from blood metonymies and metaphors to bear on the conceptualization of various domains of knowledge in SA. In particular, the study shows that blood in SA functions vis-à-vis domains of knowledge what other body parts do in other dialects of Arabic such as TA and Jordanian Arabic (JA), for instance. Such prominence of blood in Saudi oral discourse owes much to relics of the Arab-Islamic culture and the tribal structure of Saudi society. It will also be pointed out that SA implements more metonymies than metaphors to conceptualize experience.

The study has the following structure. Section 2 offers a summary of blood in the Arab culture. Section 3 addresses an overview of blood metaphors and metonymies in the literature. Section 4 develops the methodology of data collection and analysis. Section 5, which is the main one, spells out the view of blood metonymies and metaphors prevailing in SA. Section 6 discusses the findings of blood metaphors and metonymies in SA. The last section is the conclusion to the study.

2. Blood in the Arab culture

For Arabs, keeping an unstained self-image based on honor and dignity is a cultural value and practice. A famous wonder among Arabs is "what would other people say about us?" Honor occupies a preponderant place in the Arab culture in general. Nydell (2012) notes that Arabs value 3irD/šaraf (honor), karaama (dignity), and sum3a (reputation) (p. 3). Among Arab tribes, honor could only be restored through blood (honor killings).

Pre-Islamic Arabs placed tremendous faith in the therapeutic value of blood. Many pre-Islamic traditions indicate that drinking blood, particularly that of kings, priests, and leaders, had a healing physical and psychological effect. This belief extended to practices like cupping, which initially involved the sacred act of drinking the blood extracted. Additionally, Arabs in the pre-Islamic era would drink the blood of their slain enemies, believing it contained their spirit and granted life and power. Sacred trees were also irrigated with blood as part of their worship rituals. However, the advent of Islam prohibited the consumption and use of blood.

Blood was considered a sacred value among Arabs. Alliances, which were a key factor in kinship and lineage, were often sealed with blood through specific rituals that imbued these bonds with a sacred dimension. One of the most notable rituals involved dipping the hands of allies in blood, symbolizing their unity and shared lineage. Blood alliances are among the most ancient and significant forms of partnerships among Semites and, specifically, Arab pagans, where rituals such as tasting blood or anointing sacred stones with it demonstrated the unity of blood and kinship among the participants (Hussam Al-Din, 1990, p. 204).

Among the manifestations of blood's sanctity in Arab paganism was the practice of "human blood vows," where spilling human blood was seen as a means of devotion to the deity. It was also believed that stepping on the blood of a slain individual conferred spiritual strength and fulfilled personal desires. Even menstrual blood had a peculiar role, as it was thought to cure madness and expel evil spirits. Pieces of cloth soaked in menstrual blood were hung on the sick, as it was believed to repel demons due to its impurity. Thus, menstruating women were forbidden from approaching sacred idols, as their blood was believed to offend the deity and bring misfortune (Al-Amari, 2004). Patton (1901) argued that "the shedding of blood rests upon the fundamental Semitic notion that the blood holds the life, and that the life is sacred to the god of the tribe or community" (p. 703).

From an anthropological perspective, kinship and lineage in Arab societies were largely dependent on tribal solidarity, which was fuelled by two key factors: the belief in the purity of blood ties and the shared interests among tribesmen through alliances with other tribes. Tribal solidarity in Bedouin societies was akin to nationalism in modern urban societies. The Bedouin society recognized the authority of tribal leadership to manage its affairs and protect its interests. This tribal solidarity extended to alliances, which included tribes connected by lineage, proximity, or mutual pacts. Kinship among Arabs was often validated through the shared blood that flowed in the veins of all tribe members. The belief in descent from a common ancestor implied belonging to a pure and untainted bloodline, a concept referred to as "the bond of blood," which Ibn Khaldun identified as a key pillar of tribal solidarity based on blood unity and kinship ties (Ibn Khaldun, 1905, p. 104). This connection led kin to loyalty to one another in all matters, as seen in the strong emphasis on vengeance. In tribal law, an attack on one member was considered an attack on the entire tribe, necessitating retribution, which was seen as a tribal duty comparable to modern national obligations (Okasha, 2002, p. 45).

In sum, blood in the Arab culture, both ancient and modern, is a central symbol of social cohesion and spiritual beliefs. Whether in lineage and tribal solidarity or in pagan rituals, blood carried profound meanings that underscore its pivotal role in structuring Arab life and beliefs. The pertinence of some of this valuation of blood can still be seen in the blood metaphors and metonymies surviving in SA.

3. Overview of blood-related studies

Apart from Charteris-Black (2001), Simo (2011), Zibin (2021), and perhaps a few others, blood metaphors are relatively understudied compared to body parts in various languages and cultures. In Table (1) below, each separated by a decade from the other, three important studies of blood metaphors and their target domains (TD) will be displayed and discussed:

Table 1
Classification of blood metaphors in the literature by target domain

Charteris-Black (2001)	Simo (2011)		Zibin (2021)	
Ancestry	Emotion		Emotion	
Life	Essence		Essence	
Temperament		Origin		Origin
		Significance		Significance
		Quality		Quality
		Life		Life/death
			Character trait	

One shared feature in the three publications is the existence of the TD of LIFE in three pairs of languages, namely, English-Malay (Charteris-Black, 2001), Hungarian-English (Simó, 2011), and Arabic-English (Zibin, 2021). However, Simó and Zibin seem to depart from Charteris-Black's



categories of ANCESTRY and TEMPERAMENT, which have been called different names using ESSENCE by both authors.

Charteris-Black (2001) was among the first few to devote a corpus-based study to blood metaphors, isolating three major "conceptual keys" (p. 274) as shown in Table (1) above. Charteris-Black's conceptual keys are not only transparent but could also help to construct conceptual metonymies such as BLOOD FOR ANCESTRY, BLOOD FOR LIFE, and BLOOD FOR TEMPERAMENT. Charteris-Black (2001) explained that those conceptual keys carry out a figurative meaning rather than a literal one. However, he does not distinguish between metaphor and metonymy or other figures because the rules of phrasing may differ from one language to another.

Through a corpus-based study, Simó (2011), unlike Charteris-Black, isolated two major conceptual keys, namely, EMOTION and ESSENCE, with the latter divided into four subcategories such as origin, significance, quality, and life (p. 289). The sub-categories under ESSENCE do not, however, seem to be as predictable as the ones offered by Charteris-Black in terms of what examples could serve to illustrate them. Adopting Simó's categories of EMOTIONS and ESSENCE and their correlates, Zibin added another major category represented by CHARACTER TRAITS.

There are quite a few studies of blood metaphors and metonymies in the African context. Working on Afrikaans and Northern Sotho, Bosman & Taljard (2021) lined up more with Charteris-Black than with Simó, classifying target themes as LIFE, EMOTIONS, and INHERITANCE (p. 16), which is a rephrasing of Charteris-Black's ANCESTRY. Working on Hausa, a Chadic language spoken in West African countries, Shehu (2022) found blood to be prevalent in emotions and character traits, and isolated cultural metaphors such as BLOOD IS LIFE/DEATH, BLOOD IS KINSHIP RELATIONS, and BLOOD IS SACRIFICE.

In the Arabic tradition published in English, apart from Maalej (2004) and Zibin (2021), blood metaphors in Arabic dialects are understudied. In Tunisian Arabic (TA), for instance, blood is used to conceptualize the emotion of anger, personal attributes, and cultural values, with blood occasionally undergoing various cultural transformations (Maalej, 2004, pp. 57-8). For Jordanian Arabic, Zibin (2021) found blood to be used as a source domain in the conceptualization of emotions, character traits, and essence (i.e. origin, significance, quality, and life/death). The current paper means to bridge this gap by contributing data from the SA dialect and culture.

4. Methodology

Methodologically, studies in cognitive linguistics have migrated in data collection methods from almost exclusive reliance on introspection and qualitative research to more data-driven or data-based quantitative empirical research (Geeraerts, 2006). Such an enterprise gave this research paradigm more reliability and credibility regarding its conclusions and findings. For instance, Shutova et al (2013) showed through an annotated corpus that, among other things, "a large proportion of linguistic metaphors (68 %) are represented by verbs" (p. 1281). Without a corpus-based methodology, such a finding would only be arrived at with a tedious and time-consuming manual data collection technique and strenuous data analysis.

Modern spoken Arabic dialects are known for their diglossic dimension. Arabic includes a high variety called Fusha, often equated with Modern Standard Arabic (MSA), for which written corpora exist, and 22 low varieties called vernaculars (corresponding to the number of Arab countries). Data for such dialects is complex to transcribe because the diacritics for lexical items cannot emulate and capture the phonological features of the dialect. I refrained from using existing blood datasets in MSA since such data are not naturally-occurring speech but concocted by literary persons, journalists as TV presenters, or religious authorities. This situation leads researchers of such language varieties to rely almost exclusively on introspection as a data collection technique and, if the size of the corpus allows it, proceed with a qualitative analysis.

Unlike Simó (2011), whose data on blood metaphorical expressions was taken from all periods of written fiction and non-fiction of English and Hungarian literature (some of those expressions are dead or forgotten in the spoken language and culture of today), the author in the

present paper chose to work on figurative language in the Saudi society, including metaphor, metonymy, as expressions used in the daily life of native speakers of five major spoken SA varieties (Central, Hijazi, Gulf, Northern, and Southern).

The primary sources for the dataset are the social media (twitter, websites, talkbacks) and native speakers of various Saudi dialects. A total of 157 expressions were collected for SA, with only 59 retained for study. The discrepancy between collected and retained expressions owes much to the fact that the discarded ones were found to be used literally, describing blood scenes such as in killings or accidents. To ensure the reliability of data collection, the present author listed all the expressions without mentioning their sources and sent the list to 42 native speakers of all SA sub-dialects (10 male colleagues, 10 male students, and 17 males and 5 female native speakers currently living where those dialects are spoken). Those 42 informants checked the data collected from social media.

5. Blood metaphors and metonymies in SA

In the SA dialects, the sub-body part of blood is used metaphorically as a psychological embodiment to create major conceptual keys, as in "BLOOD FOR EMOTION," from which various expressions of metonyms are developed and employed in the daily spoken SA dialects and culture. Those metonyms could be subsumed under "PHYSIOLOGICAL EFFECTS OF AN EMOTION STAND FOR THE EMOTION" (Kövecses, 1995).

5.1. Blood in emotions

This section will discuss the conceptualization of the emotions of anger, fear, love, sadness, and shame, using blood as a source domain (SD).

5.1.1. Blood in the emotion of anger

SA conceptualizes the emotion of anger in accordance with the conceptual key "THE BODY IS A CONTAINER FOR THE EMOTIONS," "ANGER IS HEAT", and "EMOTIONS ARE FLUIDS" (Kövecses, 1995: pp. 181-196). Accordingly, the expressions below were built on the idea that the human body is a container, with the level of blood in the body measuring the degree of anger as a thermometer does to temperature. That is, when the anger intensifies within a person, the blood heats up and rises to various stages of anger, as in the following expressions:

(1)

دمي يغلي

dam.mi jey.li

blood-my boil-IMPERF¹

'My blood is boiling.'

I'm furious.

(2)

على الدم في راسو

ka.la edam fi ra:su

boiled the blood in head-his

'The blood has been boiled in his head.'

He is extremely angry.

Examples (1-2) capitalize on blood boiling in the body to conceptualize anger, with the difference that in (1) blood is in the process of boiling while in (2) blood has already reached the boiling point.



This is why, as an expression of anger, (2) is more intense than (1). Both conceptualizations may be controlled by the conceptual metonymy, BOILING BLOOD STANDS FOR ANGER.

When blood comes under intense heat, it may let out steam and overflow as in (3-4) below:

(3)

دمي ناير

dam.mi θa:.jer

blood-my- IMPERF erupting

'My blood is erupting.'

I am boiling mad.

(4)

فور دمي

faw.war da.mi

boil up-PERF [he] blood-my

'He bubbled up my blood.'

He made me fume.

In (3), the reaction of blood to angering event is conceptualized in the conceptual metaphor, BLOOD IS A VOLCANO. Examples (3) and (4) are governed by the conceptual metonymy, STEAMING BLOOD STANDS FOR INTENSE ANGER.

However, the boiling process of blood may not always be as explicit as in (1-2) above as in what follows:

(5)

دمي يطبخ

da.mi jat.bu.x

blood-[mine] cook-IMPERF

'My blood is cooking.'

I'm incensed.

(6) دمي محروق

d.mi mahru:q

blood my burned-PERF

'My blood is burnt.'

I am livid.

(7)

أحرق دمك

?ah.rig dam.mak

[I] burn-IMPERF blood-your

'I will burn your blood.'

I'll make you regret your deed.

In (5), yetbux (cooking) is driven by the conceptual metaphor, BLOOD IS COOKED FOOD, whereby food is not for consumption. It is a signal for imminent outburst of anger. As with food, too much heat in cooking blood causes it to burn as in (6). In (7), "burning someone's blood, unlike (6) which states that the speaker is already angry, conveys to the listener that the speaker means to threaten him, and make him regret his deed.

While in (1-7), anger depends on three heat-related processes such as boiling, cooking, and burning, that depict different intensities, the heat of blood could go down when angered individuals are pacified with the expression in (8), which means that it is not worth getting angry:

(8)

رَوَّقَ دَمِي

ro:.wəq dam.mi

[it] calm-PERF blood-mine

'It calmed my blood.'

It cooled me down.

It should be mentioned that SA is not much different than other dialects of Arabic (Maalej, 2004, for TA, and Zibin, 2021 for JA), in showing that BLOOD and HEAT interact with each other to conceptualize anger, using metaphor and metonymy.

5.1.2. Blood in the emotion of fear

Apart from anger, SA builds on the conceptual key "EMOTIONS ARE FLUIDS" in conceptualizing the emotion of fear as in the following examples:

(9)

جَمَدَ الدَّمُ فِي عُرُوقِي

dʒam.mad ed'dm fi ʕuru:.qi

freeze-PERF the blood in veins-my

'Blood froze in my veins.'

My blood run cold.

(10)

نَشَفَ دَمُو

naʃ.ʃaf dam.mo

he dried blood his

'He dried out his blood.'

He scared him.

It is interesting to note that, though the Saudi culture makes use of the EMOTIONS ARE FLUIDS, it actually makes changes to blood. The first construal of fear in (9) freezes blood in the veins, disabling the circulatory system in the body as an effect of fear. If blood is frozen, the brain will experience a lack of oxygen and nutrients to keep it operating, suggesting the conceptual metaphor FEAR IS INSTANT DEATH. The other construal of fear occurring in (10) pumps out or dries the body of its blood, suggesting the conceptual metaphor, THE BODY IS A CONTAINER FOR EMOTION. Thus, in both construals fear is a direct cause of death.

5.1.3. Blood in the emotion of love

The conceptual key, BLOOD FOR EMOTIONS, also shows that blood in SA is employed figuratively to express the emotion of love, as in the following expressions:

(11)

حُبَّكَ يَجْرِي بِدَمِي

hub.bak jeg.ri bi.dam.mi



love-your run-IMPERF in-blood-my
'Your love is running in my blood.'
I am crazy about you.

(12)

دمو يعرفني
da.mo bʕuru:.qi
blood-his in veins-my
'His blood is in my veins.'
I love him so much.

(13)

دمنا واحد
dam.na wa:.hed
blood [our] one
'Our blood is one.'
Together forever.

(14)

دمو غالي
dam.mo ʕa:.li
blood-his precious
'His blood is precious.'
He is a real gentleman.

In (11-14), the speaker depicts himself as the recipient of his beloved's blood. In (11), BLOOD IS A CONTAINER FOR LOVE, with this love running in the container. Once it is established that blood and love concurrently run, the beloved's blood becomes, through a cultural leap, the speaker's blood as in (12) through the metonym, CONCRETE FOR ABSTRACT, where blood is concrete and love is abstract. In (13), the category of blood as love runs in the blood of each beloved as per the logic of symmetry in (11). Since BLOOD IS LOVE, the beloved's blood or love is dear to the speaker.

SA also conceptualizes love from the perspective of the beloved as a recipient as in (15) and (16) below:

(15)

أسفك من دمي
ʔasqi:k men dam.mi
[I] make you drink-FUT from blood-my
'I will make you drink from my blood.'
I would give up my life for your love.

(16)

صبوا دمي جوف قلبك
sʕab.bu: dam.mi dʒawf ʔal.bak
[they] pour-PREF blood-me inside heart-your
'Let them pour my blood inside your heart.'
I would die for you.

In (15), blood was offered to the beloved as a beverage, defying the depletability of blood in the body. In (16), the speaker offers to forsake his blood by pouring it in the beloved's heart. Both expressions suggest the conceptual metaphor, LOVE IS A FLUID.

The conceptual key BLOOD FOR LOVE, which may be unique to SA, exists neither in TA (Maalej, 2004), nor in JA (Zibin, 2021). From a cultural point of view, this somewhat unique conceptualization of love in Saudi society, owes much to tribal blood ties. The blood metaphors and metonymies of love highlight the fact that lovers in SA trade a precious possession - blood - for love.

5.1.4. Blood in the emotion of sadness

Apart from anger, fear, and love, discussed previously, blood is also used as a SD to conceptualize sadness in SA as in the following examples.

(17)

بكيت دم
bakajt dam
[I] cry-PERF blood.
'I cried blood.'
I cried out of sorrow.

(18)

يدمي القلب
jud.mi: alqalb
[it] make bleed-IMPERF the heart.
'The heart bleeds.'
It makes your heart break.

These expressions show some difference at the level of SD. In (17), crying is assimilated with blood instead of tears, which suggests the conceptual metonymy, CRYING BLOOD STANDS FOR SADNESS. However, in (18) the linguistic category of blood functions as a verb (yedmi: make bleed), with the heart as a target. As a result, the mapping in (18) occurs from a concrete experienced body-part of heart to the abstract emotion of sadness, suggesting the metonymy of A BLEEDING HEART STANDS FOR SADNESS. It is worth noting that sadness in JA is not conceptualized through blood. It is construed as sadness is in the face or his face is black (Abu Rumman et al, 2024: p. 15), where, respectively, THE FACE IS A CONTAINER FOR EMOTION or A CHANGE OF FACE COLOR TO BLACK STANDS FOR SADNESS. Moreover, Maalej (personal communication) confided that sadness in TA is talked about literally, saying, for instance, *حَالُو يَحْزَنُ الْقَلْبُ* (literally, his situation makes your heart sad).

5.1.5. Blood in shame

In SA, blood is also associated with the expression of shame as in the following examples:

(19)

إخس على دَمَك
ʔex.s: ʕa.le dam.mak
Shame on blood-your
'Shame on your blood.'
Shame on you.



(20)

يا دملك!

ja dam.mak

Oh, blood-your!

‘What blood is yours?’

Seriously!

The expression in (19) in SA combines “ixs” with “blood.” On its own, “ixs” originates in Classical Arabic “ixs aa,” which is a command meaning “stay away” and “disdain.” In SA, (19) is used to rebuke and scorn those who shamelessly commit wrongdoing, expressing disgust or disdain for them. In (20), “ya dam-mak!” uses the vocative “ya” with the word “dam” to indicate a negative quality or behavior, often expressing a person’s triviality and negativity. This expression is frequently used in the context of resentment or mockery, expressing astonishment at a strange or unobjectionable behavior or action. The metonymy in these expressions is USING BLOOD DISDAINFULLY/RESENTFULLY STANDS FOR LACK OF SHAME.

5.2. Blood in evaluation

Among humans, evaluating the other is a social practice, usually done through positive or negative adjectives in various cultures. Such evaluations may include the adjectives (un)kind, good-bad, etc. In SA, evaluating the other is expressed through the SD of blood as part-whole metonymies, with blood considered as part of the individual’s body.

To evaluate others, the Saudi culture draws on many evaluative adjectives that post-modify blood. Positive evaluation conveys a favorable opinion while negative evaluation is stamped by an unfavorable opinion. SA, both positively and negatively, capitalizes on weight, cleanliness/filthiness, cheapness, and corruption/pollution to conceptualize the other’s behavior or personality. It is interesting to note here how the Saudi culture seems to put an individual’s blood to weigh it on a scale to convey a favorable opinion of them. This practice has been pointed out by Maalej (2014) for TA in connection with the body part of hand, whereby a light hand stands for industriousness (and theft) and a heavy hand for weak productivity.

In SA, a nice person accepted by the speaker for his amusing character is said to have “light” blood, while an individual whose blood is said to be “heavy” is one who is not accepted by the speaker as a viable interlocutor except in official situations as in (21) and (22):

(21)

دمو خفيف

da.mo xefi:f

blood-his light

‘His blood is light.’

He is funny.

(22)

دمو ثقيل

dam.mo tʔi:l

blood-his ʔaʔi:l

‘His blood is heavy.’

A dull person.

(23)

دمو يتقطع بسكين

dam.mo jɪtqatʰ. tʰaʃ bɪsakkin
blood [his] cut by knife
'His blood could be cut by a knife.'
He sucks balls.

In (23), the Saudi culture transforms blood from its fluid or liquid state into a thick substance that a knife can cut. All examples abide by the primary metaphors, LIGHT IS GOOD and HEAVY IS BAD, and are associated with the conceptual metonymy, HAVING LIGHT/HEAVY/THICK BLOOD STANDS FOR FUN AND LACK OF IT.

Beside lightness and heaviness, SA evaluates others favorably by associating blood with cleanliness and sweetness and unfavorably by associating blood with filth as in the following:

(24)
دمو نظيف
dam.mo nadʰi:f
blood [his] clean
'His blood is clean.'
A straightforward person.

(25)
دمو عسل
dam.mo ʕa.sal
blood [his] honey
'His blood is honey.'
He is lovely.

While English and other languages talk about a sweet person, SA restricts sweetness to blood, which conveys the conceptual metonymy, HAVING CLEAN/SWEET BLOOD STANDS FOR A STRAIGHTFORWARD AND LOVELY INDIVIDUAL.

On the negative side, the Saudi culture categorizes people's blood as dirty, wicked, corrupt, polluted. While (24) and (25) evaluate the other's verbal behavior, the following metonymies address the others' moral behavior:

(26)
دمو وسخ
dam.mo wɪ.sɪx
blood-his dirty
'His blood is dirty.'
He is an immoral person.

(27)
دمو زنخ
da.mo zɪ.nɪx
blood-his rancid
'His blood is rancid.'
He is lazy and inert (a sack of potato).

(28)
دمو زفر
dam.mo zɪ.fɪr



blood his stinking
'His blood is stinking.'
He is so rude.

(29)

دمو نجس
dam.mo nr.dʒɪs
blood-his impure
'His blood is impure.'
He is an objectionable individual.

Although the adjectives used with blood in (26-29) above are all related to filth, each one of them conveys a different meaning as can be described, respectively, in the following conceptual metonymies: HAVING DIRTY BLOOD STANDS FOR AN IMMORAL INDIVIDUAL, HAVING RANCID BLOOD STANDS FOR A LAZY INDIVIDUAL, HAVING STINKING BLOOD STANDS FOR RUDENESS, and HAVING IMPURE BLOOD STANDS FOR AN OBJECTIONABLE INDIVIDUAL.

The list of blood expressions extends to other adjectives that denote corruption and pollution as in (30) and (31) below:

(30)

دمو فاسد
dam.mo faː.sɪd²
blood-his corrupt
'His blood is corrupt.'
He is a wicked person.

(31)

دمو ملوث
dam.mo malaw.waθ
blood-his blotted
'His blood is blotted.'
His blood is not noble but mixed.

Examples (30) and (31) are derived from the conceptual metonymies, HAVING CORRUPT BLOOD STANDS FOR A WICKED INDIVIDUAL and HAVING A POLLUTED BLOOD STANDS FOR AN ANTI-GENTLEMAN.

SA taints blood black to conceptualize selfishness and blue to conceptualize immorality as in (32) and (33) below:

(32)

دمو أسود
dam.mo ʔas.wad
blood-his black
'His blood is black.'
He is selfish.

(33)

دمو أزرق
dam.mo ʔaz.raʔ

blood-his blue
'His blood is blue.'
He is a dirty man.

These blood expressions are culture-specific, associating blood with black and blue colors, thus describing the conceptual metonymies, HAVING BLACK BLOOD STANDS FOR A SELFISH INDIVIDUAL and HAVING BLUE BLOOD STANDS FOR AN IMMORAL INDIVIDUAL.

Apart from drawing on weight, dirt, pollution, corruption, and color to conceptualize various target domains, SA capitalizes on denying or eliminating the existence in an individual's body as in (34) below:

(34)

ما فيه دم
ma fi: dam
No in-it blood
'He has no blood.'
He is shameless.

Since it is impossible biologically to empty an individual's body from its blood contents, culture has a lot to do with associating this with shamelessness. The cultural metonymy governing shamelessness is HAVING NO BLOOD STANDS FOR SHAMELESSNESS.

5.3. Blood in cultural practices

Blood has a wide application in SA. As seen above, blood conceptualizes emotions and people's behaviors and attributes. In this sub-section, blood is used to conceptualize retribution, face recognition, threats and intolerance, over-exploitation, and economic transactions.

5.3.1. Blood revenge

As pointed out in Section 1, blood is culturally connected with retribution, i.e. taking one's revenge over an offender from another kinship. While nowadays such justice making is taken care mostly by legal courts established by the state of Saudi Arabia to control civil war, retribution is still partly observed especially in rural areas in Saudi Arabia. Patton (1901) argues that "in blood-revenge more than in many other features of Arab life we find expressed the aristocratic feeling of family honor common to tribal peoples generally, but in Arabia prevailing to a degree rarely met with elsewhere" (p. 704). This may perhaps explain why SA contains a great deal of blood metaphors and metonymies. The following examples illustrate genuine retribution:

(35)

الدم بالدم
ald:am bald:am
the blood by the blood
'Blood begets blood.'
An eye for an eye.

(36)

الدم يغسل بالدم
ald:am ju:ysal bald:am
the blood washed by blood
'Blood cannot be washed without blood'.



As they sow, so let them reap.

(37)

بينهم دم

bej.nhum dam

between them blood

‘There is blood between them’.

There is blood revenge between them.

(38)

ناخذ بدقو

na:.xod bɪdam.mo

We take by blood-his

‘We will revenge his blood’.

We will revenge him.

Thus, the metonymy that unites the foregoing expressions in (35-38) is BLOOD COUNTERING BLOOD STANDS FOR REVENGE.

There are expressions in SA that exhort the listener to shed blood, which is actually not revenge but an exhortation to pluck up courage and undertake something important regardless of consequences as in the following:

(39)

اقطع العرق وسجّ دمو

ʔiq.tʰaʕ lʕerr w ssaj.jih dam.mo

cut the vein and spill blood-its

‘Cut the vein and spill its blood’.

Just do it, no matter what it takes.

(40)

سيل الدم ولا تندم

se:l ʔadam wa la tɪndam

spill-IMP the blood and no [you] regret-IMPERF

‘Spill the blood and don’t regret.’

Don’t care about the consequences.

The metonymy underlying this is SHEDDING BLOOD IS UNDERTAKING AN IMPORTANT DEED.

5.3.2. Blood in face recognition

A special use of blood in SA is for an individual to guess which physical and behavioral resemblance observed interlocutors may have with others simply by looking at their face. This can be called folk face recognition as in (41) and (42).

(41)

يرمي الدم

jer.mi eldam

[he] throw-IMPERF the blood

‘He throws the blood.’

He tries to recognize kinship.

(42)

فيه من دَمُو

fī: min 'dam.mo

In him some blood-his

'He has some of his blood.'

He looks like him.

In actual fact, when individuals make guesses as to the approximate family belonging of the observed individual, they are actually not looking at the blood but at the face, which describes the conceptual metaphor BLOOD IS FACE. Yet, Saudis call this throwing the blood at the face of an individual to guess his origin through resemblance with other individuals. However, such guessing of kinship through the face is not actually specific to SA.³

5.3.3. Blood in threats and (in)tolerance

Beside conceptualizing revenge and face recognition in blood terms, SA also conceptualizes threatening someone through the SD of blood as in the following expressions:

(43)

أَسْجِجْ دَمَكَ

?asajjiħ dam.mak

spill-IMPERF [I] blood [your]

'I will spill your blood.'

I will make you bleed to death.

(44)

أَشْرِبْ دَمَكَ

?aħ.rab dam.mak

I drink-FUT blood-your.

I will drink your blood.

I am going to kill you.

(45)

أَطْرَشْكَ الدَّم

?atrʔaħ idam

I vomit you the blood

'I'll make you vomit your blood.'

I'll make you suffer.

Like English, which does not have "to threaten" as a speech act, SA threatens people via alternative blood expressions. In cognitive linguistics, this is called construal, which is the capacity "to construe the same content in alternate ways, resulting in substantially different meanings" (Langacker, 2000, p. 5). This construal is reflected in the conceptual metonymy, SHEDDING/DRINKING/AND MAKING SOMEONE VOMIT THEIR BLOOD IS THREATENING THEM.

The foregoing expressions are used to conceptualize dislike for other people in blood terms:



(46)

دَمِي وَدَمُو مَا اتَّفَقُوا

dam.mi w dam.mo ma ʔita.faqu/

blood [my] and blood [his] no agree-PERF

My blood and his never matched.

We do not tolerate each other.

The use of blood in (46) above builds on the part-whole metonymy, BLOOD FOR PERSON, generating the conceptual metonymy, DISAGREEMENT BETWEEN BLOODS STANDS FOR DISLIKE. While English says we do not agree with each other, in SA my blood and his blood do not agree or match.

Dislike in SA is also construed in terms of blood but this time by putting someone underneath one's tooth as in (47) below:

(47)

حَاطَهُ دَمَ ضَرْسُو

ħa.tʰ.tʰo dam dʕir.su/

Put-IMPERF him blood molar-his

He puts him underneath his molar.

He reluctantly accepts him.

In (47), to put someone under one's molar means that you cannot stand them, suppress your anger and rage towards them, and force yourself to reluctantly deal with them. The conceptual metonymy governing this is HAVING SOMEONE UNDERNEATH ONE'S MOLAR STANDS FOR DISLIKING THEM.

5.3.4. Blood in (over)exploitation

As a TD, overexploitation is another indication of the wide-ranging use of blood metonymies in SA as in what follows:

(48)

شَفَطَ دَمُو

ʃa.fat dam.mo

[he] suck-PERF blood his

'He sucked his blood.'

He overexploited him.

(49)

مَصَّ دَمِي

mas: dam.mi

suck-PERF [he] blood-my

He sucked my blood.

He took advantage of me.

The overexploitation of an individual by another, which is stripping this individual from all his belongings, is conceptualized through sucking his blood, thus making him empty-handed. Examples (48) and (49) are governed by the conceptual metonymy, SUCKING SOMEONE'S BLOOD STANDS FOR OVEREXPLOITING THEM. It should be noted that JA also includes

such expressions, which denote taking advantage of someone both financially and emotionally (Zibin, 2021: p. 40).⁴

However, the individual mentioned in (51) is not already overexploited but the speaker issued an evil prayer for the addressee to be exploited by the others as a way of revenging themselves on him.

(50)

امتصّوا دمّك

ʔimtʕas:u dam.mak

suck-IMPERF [they] blood you

I wish they suck your blood.

Let the devil get hands on you.

The conceptual metonymy for (50) is WISHING FOR THE DEVIL TO SUCK SOMEONE'S BLOOD IS TO SEE THEM OVEREXPLOITED.

5.3.5. Blood in economic transactions

Saudis are traditionally known for being prosperous tradesmen and successful entrepreneurs. The adoption of blood as a SD for economic transactions is testimony for the valuation of trade via the valuation of blood in one's life and for one's survival as in the following expressions.

(51)

حطّيت دم قلبي

hattʕe:t dam qal.bi

Put-PERF [I] blood heart-my

'I put the blood of my heart.'

I paid a big price for it.

(52)

لقمة بدمها

loq.ma bɪdam.ha

bite by blood-its

'A bite by its blood.'

He accomplished an extremely hard task.

(53)

دم نابو

dam na:.bo

blood fang-his

'The blood of his fang.'

He suffered to achieve what he did.

(54)

شم ريحة الدم

ʃam ri:hit idam

[he] smell-PERF smell of the blood



'He sensed the smell of blood'
Where there is blood, there is plenty of food.

In (51)⁵, the high value of blood in the Saudi culture is projected onto an economic enterprise, whereby blood becomes an investment into such an enterprise. This expression entails that the speaker's resources, both pecuniary and physical, have been exhausted into the enterprise. In (52), the speaker signals that his enterprise would not have been successful without sweating so much in undertaking it. In (53), the person in question has exerted considerable effort or suffered significantly in order to achieve something. In this sense, it is a well-deserved achievement as it is gained through the blood of one's fang. The conceptual metonymy for the expressions above is VALUING BLOOD HIGHLY STANDS FOR ECONOMIC TRANSACTION. In (54), however, the smell of the blood of slaughtered animals, such as camels, sheep, or goats – a common practice in the Arabian Gulf – provokes wild animals like wolves to prey, which suggests the metonymy blood-for-food. It also suggests the conceptual metaphor, MAN IS A PREDATOR, from which can be inferred the quality of being carnivorous or aroused by the smell of blood.

5.3.6. Other blood metonymies

This sub-section includes multifarious uses of blood metaphors and metonymies in the conceptualization of some TDs, which testifies to wide-ranging application of blood in SA. Grouping them here is for convenience and because each one expresses a different meaning that cannot be linked to another one.

(55)
دمو رخيص
dam.mo raxi:s⁶
blood-his cheap
'His blood is cheap.'
He is worthless.

(56)
يا دمي يا دمك
ja dam.mi ja dam.mak
Either blood-my either blood-your
'It is either my blood or yours.'
One of us will kill the other.

(57)
يلعب بدمو
jel.ʕab bɪdam.mo
[he] play-IMPERF with blood-his
'He is playing with his blood.'
He is endangering his life.

(58)
تغسل بالدم

tysal bīd.dam

[you] wash-IMPERF with blood

‘Wash yourself with blood.’

To sacrifice an animal for the sake of Allah as a sign of thanks for your safety.

(59)

دم؟ دم

dam? dæm

blood? blood.

‘Agreed?’

Agreed forever.

In (55), the value of blood is depreciated to conceptualize a worthless person, which is a BLOOD-FOR-PERSON metonymy. Deriving logically from (55), SA holds a respectable individual to have invaluable blood. Expression (56) is uttered as part of a preparation for a fight and a bloody one, which builds on BLOOD-FOR-LIFE metonymy. In (57), the same BLOOD-FOR-LIFE metonymy prevails, but this time in conceptualizing playing with one’s blood as endangering one’s life. In (58), the superstition that if something evil happens to someone, they should shed an animal’s blood is deeply rooted in the Arab culture. The animal could even be a rooster up to a sheep or a cow.

The metonymy here is WASHING AN EVENT WITH BLOOD STANDS FOR SACRIFICING AN ANIMAL TO THIS EFFECT. In (59), a vow for agreement is made between two individuals via using the lexical item of blood, which stands for mutual sacrificing of one’s life. A tentative metonymy for (60) may be TAKING A BLOOD OATH STANDS FOR MUTUAL SACRIFICING OF ONE’S LIFE.

6. Discussion

The dataset of this research shows that SA relies heavily on blood metonymies. This is due to the continued use of the Saudi dialect as a daily language of communication among tribesmen throughout the ages without interruption or influence from any external linguistic sources since there wasn’t any other spoken language in Arabia. The importance allotted to blood ties in Arab tribes in Saudi Arabia has lent hand to and strengthened the marked use of blood metaphors and metonymies in SA vernaculars. For instance, when an individual trades his blood for someone’s love and appreciation, it means that love is as precious as blood, which has been shown to stand for life as in examples (15) and (16) above.

The wider application of blood metaphors and metonymies in SA can be shown through a simple comparison with two other dialects of Arabic. The current study amply documented the use of blood in emotions in SA, which conceptualizes anger, fear, love, sadness, and shame in blood metaphors and metonymies. For TA, it has been attested by Maalej (2004, 2007) that the SD of blood is prevalent in anger and fear but not in love, sadness, and shame. Similarly, for JA Zibin (2021) only mentioned the TDs of anger and fear (p. 42). If blood in anger and fear can be found not only in the Arab context but also in other languages and cultures as part of a physiological embodiment, the conceptualization of the TDs of love, sadness, and shame in blood terms can be argued to be somewhat specific to SA. If face recognition in terms of blood may be found in many dialects of Arabic, SA can be singled out as unique in conceptualizing economic transactions and



overexploitation in blood terms. Clearly, as a SD blood is more productive in conceptualizing TDs in SA.

Another area worth considering in SA is the TDs conceptualized via blood metaphors and metonymies. Since there is no study so far on blood per se in TA, I will compare SA with JA. In (10) above, drying out someone's blood in the veins in SA stands for scaring them. However, in JA drying out someone's blood stands for anger as described in the conceptual metaphor, METAPHORICAL DRYNESS OF BLOOD STANDS FOR ANGER (Alazazmeh & Zibin, 2022: p. 434). As analyzed in this study, the TDs of the SD of blood in SA include revenge, face recognition, threats and intolerance, overexploitation, economic transactions, and other domains such as sacrifice and agreement. However, in JA the focus is different, selecting for the SD of blood TDs such as some character traits, life/death (also found in SA), origin, and quality (Zibin, 2021) as spelt out in Table 1 (section 2) above.

It is interesting to discuss the dominance of metonymies over metaphors in conceptualizing TDs in SA. Lakoff (1987) holds metonymy to be a "stand-for relation" (p. 78). At the risk of repetition, the conceptual metonymy of (17) above is CRYING BLOOD STANDS FOR SADNESS, where the leftmost items to "stands for" are the SD and the rightmost one is the TD. Working on head metaphors and metonymies, Maalej (2014) found that, compared to metaphor, metonymy is far more productive in the conceptualization of character traits and cultural values (Maalej, 2014, p. 224). Kraska-Szlenk (2019) argued that "extensions driven by metonymy tend to be more common cross-linguistically than those triggered by metaphor," calling them "soft cognitive universals" (Kraska-Szlenk, 2019, p. 150). The possible justification for such a dominance may be sought in cultural embodiment as in the conceptual metonymy, CRYING BLOOD STANDS FOR SADNESS as against universal, biological embodiment attested in many languages and cultures in the conceptual metaphor, EMOTION IS A HOT FLUID IN A CONTAINER.

7. Conclusion

The present article aimed at studying blood-related metaphors and metonymies in SA. The findings showed that SA, compared, for instance, to JA and TA, employs more blood-related metonymies with emotions. SA also differs from JA and TA in terms of the way it evaluates other peoples' personality traits by employing a range of semantic categories such as weight (light/heavy), cleanliness and filth (clean, dirty, rancid, stinking, impure, corrupt, polluted, etc.), and colors (black and blue). Moreover, SA offers somewhat unique cultural practices such as blood revenge, face recognition, threats/intolerance, overexploitation, economic transactions, etc., which are crystallized in blood metonymies.

This article has explained the complex ways in which blood metaphors and metonymies serve as fundamental vehicles for expressing emotions and other TDs in SA. In examining the metaphors and metonymies associated with blood, this study highlighted a blending of universal embodiment with anger and fear and a cultural embodiment with love, sadness, and shame, which is profoundly influenced by the Saudi culture that highlights the significance of blood as a symbol of identity and connection. Furthermore, the metonymies used in evaluating the others and the cultural practices deeply reflect the influence of culture on Saudi thought and language.

If the influence of the tribal culture is clear in SA via blood-related metonymies, it is not so clear why Jordan, which partly includes tribes, did not produce the same effect in JA (see, Zibin, 2021). Indeed, Zibin & Hamdan (2019) addressed, for instance, JA fear metaphors, metonymies, and 'metaphonymies', in which blood is almost nonexistent. To ascertain the status of blood metonymies in Arabic and the influence of tribal culture, there is need to investigate a substantial quantity of dialects of Arabic, especially in other Gulf states to see how they compare to SA.

Endnotes

¹ The following abbreviations are used throughout the article: PERF (Perfect), IMPERF (Imperfect), PASS (Passive), FUT (Future), MASC (masculine), FEM (feminine), IMP (imperative)

² Maalej (personal communication) assured me that *dam fasid* (corrupt blood) does exist in TA in conceptualizing extreme anger but not in evaluating other peoples' behavior or personality.

³ Maalej (personal communication) confirmed the existence of such a practice in TA.

⁴ One of the reviewers drew my attention to the fact that the very same expression also exists in TA to conceptualize exploitation.

⁵ One of the reviewers drew my attention to the fact that the very same expression also exists in TA to conceptualize economic transactions.

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